



On the 27th of Adar I, 5752 (Monday, March 2, 1992), the Lubavitcher Rebbe, Rabbi Menachem Mendel Schneerson, suffered a disabling stroke while praying. On the same date two years later, the Rebbe lost consciousness following another stroke. COLlive is republishing a 1992 article by Dina Rabinovitch for The Independent.

*The Messiah is here in Brooklyn
In the ghetto of Crown Heights, a passion for Jewish orthodoxy and a fixation with a 90-year-old sage whose remarkable teacher, but his followers than that.*

By DINA RABINOVITCH
Saturday, 12 December 1992

Crown Heights, Brooklyn: litter blows down neighbourhood with crack addi there is another population which do orthodox Jews of mystical inclination, Hasidim living according to strict religious tradition, the men with beards, long sidelocks and the black coats and hats of 18th-century eastern Europe; their wives wearing



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wigs, mandatory after marriage, their children remarkable for their number.

In the summer of 1991 there were three days of rioting by blacks screaming 'Get the Jew', during which one Jew was killed. In another case, which has yet to come to court, a local Jewish woman was assaulted and murdered in her living-room. But look heavenwards and find uplift. Huge banners stretched from telegraph wires proclaim: 'The Messiah is on his Way!' What they actually mean is that the Messiah is here; right here in Crown Heights.

It is a principle of the Jewish faith that the Messiah will come one day. And yet messianic movements have been rare in Jewish history. The example of Sabbatai Zevi in 1665 is the most famous. His claim to be the Messiah came against a background of Jews being persecuted in Poland and Russia. There was a huge backlash when Zevi, who was a manic depressive, converted to Islam.

For years the Hasidim of Crown Heights have nurtured the hope that the Rebbe, or leader, of the Lubavitch sect, is the Messiah. In the past six months the Rebbe's followers have put up billboards in cities with major Jewish communities announcing the arrival of the Messiah. Lubavitch vans drive around Jewish neighbourhoods broadcasting the news. And at Tel Aviv airport a notice says simply: 'He's here.'

'Our sages told us the Messiah is a man of flesh and blood,' said Rabbi **Yehuda Krinsky**, a secretary to the Lubavitcher Rebbe. 'We believe it is the Rebbe.'

Does the Rebbe believe he is the Messiah? 'Right now, the Rebbe can't tell us,' answered Rabbi Krinsky. Last March a massive stroke left him paralysed and unable to speak.

These days the Rebbe, 90-year-old **Menachem Mendel Schneersohn**, seventh leader of the Lubavitch movement, sits in a wheelchair behind the broken shutters of a red-brick building at 770 Eastern Parkway, the headquarters of his movement which has, during his 42-year tenure, been transformed from a practically moribund group of Hasidim into a powerful movement, spreading a warmth and love of Judaism to disaffected Jews, making brilliant use of modern publicity and communications, and sending out young couples to every corner of the world to bring thousands of people into the Lubavitch fold.

In contrast to other Hasidim who tend to be reclusive, Schneersohn chose the motto 'out there' – and set about it. In the Sixties, he sent out 'mitzvah tanks' – caravans that drove to remote villages. They would park at a strategic point and a bearded type in a long black coat, full of charisma, would go out to seize on any passing likely-looking Jew. It was a Tora – Jewish law. Even those who were drawn to the exuberance of these 'crazy Lubavitchers' and their warmth.

Then in the Seventies and Eighties you could be stuck in a motel somewhere, flicking through the cable TV channels, and find a little old



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man with a beard, wearing a felt hat and a long black coat, talking in a soft voice. It was the Rebbe's lectures, broadcast from Crown Heights, with translations into English; no fancy video gimmicks to make it palatable, and no apologies for being quite so obviously Jewish.

At Lubavitch headquarters you can watch tapes of the days before the Rebbe's stroke, when he handed out dollars to those visiting him – another of his ideas that captured people's imagination. Schneersohn would give a newly minted dollar to his visitors, to give to charity. The queues of both Jews and non-Jews to see the Rebbe stretched round the block.

On the videos you can see Supreme Court judges saying: 'Rabbi, I'm up for re-election; can you give me a blessing?' There's a non-Jewish politician from Uruguay who was so eager that he ran the last six blocks. And there are women with simple requests: for health, and fertility.

When he has instructed, they have obeyed. There is no other Jewish leader alive whose edicts are followed quite so religiously. Every time there is a major world event, there are stories circulated about the Rebbe and his amazing foresight. People will tell you how their close friends, or their mother's cousin, phoned the Rebbe during the Miami hurricane. Those people who followed the Rebbe's advice to stay where they were remained unscathed, whereas those who moved down the coast – following official advice – were swept up in gales. The same sorts of story are told with different backgrounds: Vietnam, or the Gulf war.

It is almost irrelevant whether the stories are true or not. There are people who believe them. The Rebbe may have lost the power of speech, but this has not stopped people asking his opinion.

The Lubavitch movement takes its name from the Belarussian town of Lybavichi, where the founding family was based. For four generations, they and their followers stayed through thick and thin, despite increasing persecution, until in 1929, the sixth Rebbe, Rabbi **Joseph Schneersohn**, moved to Warsaw and stayed until after the outbreak of the Second World War. It was only in 1940 that he decided his future lay in the United States. He arrived in New York on 19 March, and was welcomed off the SS Drottingholm by Lubavitch Hasidim who had escaped from Europe earlier. He settled in Crown Heights.

Joseph had no sons to succeed him so he named his son after his grandfather, Mendel, a cousin who had married Joseph's mother. He was a brilliant scholar, but he had also studied at the Sorbonne, from where he graduated in several languages. His grasp of both the Jewish and non-Jewish languages among Hasidic leaders, proved a potent asset to Lubavitch. He also had piercing blue eyes and an excellent memory which not only showed his intelligence but also allowed him to remember people's names.



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The subway ride to Crown Heights from mid-town Manhattan takes about 40 minutes, crossing through ever poorer neighbourhoods. For the last few stops you will see only two kinds of people on the train:

Hasidim rushing home on Friday afternoon, in time for the Sabbath, and the blacks, who co-exist uneasily with the Hasidim. All the other Jews moved out of Crown Heights in the Sixties, when it became a dangerous neighbourhood, but the Lubavitch stayed – because the Rebbe said, we are not moving.

At the end of October Crown Heights was swarming with police. A court had acquitted a black teenager of killing a young Hasid, despite what seemed to be conclusive evidence of the teenager's guilt – a bloody knife in his pocket, positive identification by the victim before he died. That killing had come after a black child was run over by a car driven by a Hasid following the Rebbe to his wife's grave.

he sense of living in a hostile neighbourhood is very marked in Crown Heights. Jews and blacks pass each other with tight, closed faces. However, Lubavitch Hasidim do not just feel beleaguered in their neighbourhood – they also feel distanced from other Hasidic sects.

Many Lubavitchers complained that the other Jews in New York didn't come and help during the summer's riots. 'Nobody cares about us,' said one woman, mother of 14 children. Part of the antagonism arises from the way Lubavitch have reached out to assimilated Jews. But there is also suspicion of the Lubavitchers' Rebbe worship; they even have spotlit portraits of their leader in their houses, an extraordinary thing in a religion which eschews all images of adoration. Menachem Mendel was handed the messianic baton by his father-in-law, who felt that the Messiah must come after the Holocaust. He did not show up, but Lubavitch children were drilled to perform their Jewish duties in order to hasten his arrival. So a generation of Jewish children has been raised with the subconscious idea that the point of Judaism is to bring the Messiah. In fact, the Jewish belief is that the point of the Messiah is to bring peace – in which to practise Judaism.

Lubavitch Hasidim's hopes are focused on this Rebbe for a number of reasons. First, Menachem Mendel is the seventh leader of the movement, and seven is a number given mystical qualities in Judaism – the Sabbath is the seventh day, for example.

Second, the 18th-century founder of the Hasidic movement, the Ba'al Shem Tov, wrote a letter to his brother telling of a dream in which the Messiah appeared to him and said that when his philosophy was spread to every corner of the world they can rightly claim that they have been propagating every word the Rebbe ever said.

On this particular October Sabbath, the pitch of expectation. The word was out of the synagogue for Friday-night prayers. In a thirsty need: to see the Rebbe.

The synagogue is a run-down building with scraps of paper flying about. Although Lubavitch has millions of dollars at its disposal – donations from supporters and the result of their own active fund-raising – the money goes not on home comforts, but on



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public relations and helping Jews round the world. Recently the sect airlifted children out of Chernobyl to take them to Israel.

The synagogue was jammed that night. We were upstairs in the women's section; as everybody told me, it was the best place to see the Rebbe. Downstairs, little boys climbed up every available ceiling support structure, and many hung perilously from the skylights.

The Friday-night worship came to an end, but the concentration in the synagogue mounted rather than lessened. A curtain heaved, then opened. 'Good Shabbos, good Shabbos, good Shabbos,' the congregation greeted the seated, hunched figure of Menachem Mendel Schneerson. He looked old, but domineering in the set way some old people do.

Very few people in Lubavitch talk about the Rebbe as one would about an ordinary human being. But one of those close to him told me how during the previous month, as the Rebbe had recovered somewhat, he had become frustrated about not being able to speak. 'It was like 20 questions. They'd be asking him what he wanted, what he felt like eating, and they couldn't get it right. It was hard.'

Downstairs, the men's section of the synagogue was a single, driven mass. 'Long live our teacher, our king, the Messiah,' they sang, and the black suits and black hats jumped up and down as one to the beat. Around me, women and girls were white with emotion.

Previously, these Hasidim would chant, 'Long life to our teacher.' Since the Rebbe's reappearance in public, they have added the words: 'the Messiah'. The Rebbe's head moved along to the singing, his hand raised as if to conduct the people.

After a minute, perhaps, Rabbi Krinsky, the secretary, leaned forward to ask something. The Rebbe's head nodded, and as the curtains slowly closed around him he raised his hand more vigorously in time to the music, as if to say: this is good, keep going.

In every synagogue in the world, Jews pray towards Jerusalem, and the Ark is always on the wall of the synagogue facing Jerusalem. But as the synagogue in Crown Heights emptied that Friday night, I could see the lay-out of the synagogue clearly for the first time. I have been standing close to the Rebbe's seat in the synagogue. Looking down I realise that the Ark containing the Tora scrolls is actually at the other end of the synagogue, behind the backs of the entire community who have all prayed facing the Rebbe.

Later I raised the matter with Rabbi Krinsky. Did you see, I ask him, people were not facing mizrach, not facing towards the East? He shrugged and looked away.

The Jewish idea of the Messiah is not the coming of a divinely inspired leader who will lead the Jews towards a model society where brotherhood and loving kindness will

Today the orthodox Jewish opposition is muted – partly out of a genuine feeling that the Rebbe is doing much in his time. But there is tremendous opposition to the

The repercussions of Sabbatai Zevi, the false messiah, afflicted Jewish life for 200 years, leading many to Christianity and Islam.

Professor **Allan Nadler**, head of the YIVO Institute in New York, an organisation dedicated to preserving Eastern European Jewish culture,



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says: 'Lubavitch are setting themselves up for the worst experience of the Jewish people – failed messianic expectations, a reaction they won't be able to control.'

Apart from anything else, for the Rebbe to be in a position to give messianic leadership would require a miraculous recovery, one which his Hasidim have not ruled out. For them, he is either the Messiah or he is going to die.

The death of the Rebbe is a taboo subject among the Lubavitch; not only is he their beloved leader, but he is the end of the line. For seven generations, the Schneersohn family have kept their followers' hopes alive through all their tribulations. But the Rebbe has no offspring; he has a nephew living in Israel, but there was a family feud over the Schneersohn family's valuable library about a decade ago; in any case, he is not an orthodox Jew. People outside Lubavitch have speculated that Adin Steinsalz, a renowned Lubavitch scholar, could become Rebbe, but he has no family connection and insiders scoff at the idea.

So while the Lubavitch look towards their transcendent moment, they are in fact in their moment of greatest crisis. For as with every movement that puts its faith in its leader, when the leader dies, the movement may follow.

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to yehuda krinsky

March 24, 2009 11:48 am

what happend to 'Our sages told us the Messiah is a man of flesh and blood,'

0 | 0 Reply

painful article

March 23, 2009 3:18 pm

but so true.

0 | 0 Reply

to 2&3

March 23, 2009 2:47 pm

where's a little faith in the rebbe's prophecy? (see sicha shabbos p. shoftim 5751[1991]et al.)
just about all promises of the rebbe took some time (and faith), and yet, they ALWAYS
materialized in the end.

on a separte note; regarding 3 tammuz: it doesn't change the rebbe's eligibility as the rebbe
himself wrote in a transcription of a excerpt of his talk on 13 shvat 5711(1951).

1 | 0 Reply

to col

March 23, 2009 2:15 pm

reading the concluding lines of article, i ask you; what's your point?
are you suggesting that pure faith (vayaaminu bahashem uvemoishe avdoi) w/out some
enlightenment, may not be the best thing for our PR?
i think you could've found a slightly more appropriate article.
i expect better from col.

1 | 0 Reply

horrible header

March 23, 2009 12:02 pm

that's the way you write about our Rebbe?!

0 | 0 Reply

good article very good

March 23, 2009 10:33 am

0 | 0 Reply

PLEASE

March 23, 2009 7:56 am

dont write it that way



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to #5 

🕒 March 23, 2009 7:54 am

why do you say someone on the top should do something, shoin genug at the top. They have failed us period end of story. It's now time for a revolution from the soldiers whom they have failed.

0 | 0  Reply

yesh roeh tzoin 

🕒 March 23, 2009 7:08 am

The Rebbe already provided what to do in these times, if only anyone on the top in Aguch Merkos etc. cared.....instead of their selfish egotistic power struggles

0 | 0  Reply

still alone in a crowd 

🕒 March 23, 2009 6:04 am

I remember so well the shock, the fear, the pain we all suffered on Chof Zayin Adar. It was the beginning of our time as fatherless children. How we have suffered & still suffer without our Rebbe b'guf. How much more bitter is our Golus today.

0 | 0  Reply

sad... but he was kid of right 

🕒 March 23, 2009 6:02 am

Professor Allan Nadler, head of the YIVO Institute in New York, an organisation dedicated to preserving Eastern European Jewish culture, says: 'Lubavitch are setting themselves up for the worst experience of the Jewish people – failed messianic expectations, a reaction they won't be able to control.'

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how sad 

🕒 March 23, 2009 4:47 am

""Lubavitch are setting themselves up for the worst experience of the Jewish people – failed messianic expectations, a reaction they won't be able to control.""

0 | 0  Reply

Phe 

🕒 March 23, 2009 4:35 am

"The Rebbe's head nodded, and as th
more vigorously in time to the music
remember what happened in lamed daled with the mitzvah tanks?

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